

Houston City College VICEROY Scholars Selected as Poster Finalists for 2026 VICEROY Symposium

Houston City College is proud to announce that four VICEROY Scholars will accompany Lieutenant Colonel Robert Glover, USMC (Retired), Executive Director for Military Education Programs, to the **2026 VICEROY Symposium at the College of William & Mary, April 13th – 16th**, where they have been selected to present as **poster competition finalists** for their project, **“Spectrum Awareness for Cyber Operators: Why EMS Matters in Cyber Defense.”**

Chosen to represent Houston City College are **Cesar Garrido, Leslie Trevino, John Heickman, and Derek Casanares, Jr.** Together, they reflect the growing strength, depth, and mission focus of the college’s VICEROY Scholars Program and its commitment to developing students prepared to contribute to the nation’s cyber and national security workforce.

Their selection as poster finalists is a meaningful achievement. The VICEROY Symposium brings together scholars, faculty, and national security stakeholders from across the country to showcase student research, innovation, and workforce development aligned to Department of Defense needs. To be recognized as finalists places these Houston City College scholars among a select group whose work has been identified as both timely and relevant to the evolving defense environment.

Their presentation, **“Spectrum Awareness for Cyber Operators: Why EMS Matters in Cyber Defense,”** addresses a critical reality of the modern operational environment: cyber defense cannot be fully understood apart from the electromagnetic spectrum. Today’s cyber operators must recognize that digital systems, communications pathways, signal activity, and spectrum conditions are increasingly interconnected. By examining why electromagnetic spectrum awareness matters in cyber defense, the team’s work demonstrates exactly the kind of cross-domain thinking the VICEROY program is designed to cultivate.

Each scholar brings a distinct strength to the team.

Cesar Garrido, the team leader and a **United States Marine Corps veteran**, brings leadership, maturity, and a service-centered perspective that grounds the project in mission relevance and disciplined execution.

Leslie Trevino, a former Houston City College VICEROY Scholar and **VICEROY MAVEN awardee**, continues to build on her success as a **current student at Texas A&M University at Galveston**, representing the kind of sustained academic and professional momentum the program is meant to generate.

John Heickman has contributed to the team’s effort through his engagement with the project and his continued commitment to strengthening his understanding of cyber and national security issues through the VICEROY experience.

Derek Casanares, Jr., a **U.S. Navy Baccalaureate Degree Completion Program (BDCP) student seeking a commission in the U.S. Navy**, represents another strong example of a scholar aligning academic preparation with future military service and leadership.

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Together, these scholars embody what Houston City College has worked to build through VICEROY: a deliberate talent development pathway that connects education to operational relevance, national security workforce needs, and a clear ethic of service. Their selection to present at the 2026 symposium is not simply a student achievement. It reflects the college's growing ability to produce scholars who can think critically, communicate effectively, and contribute meaningfully to serious defense-aligned conversations.

As they travel to the College of William & Mary this April, Cesar Garrido, Leslie Trevino, John Heickman, and Derek Casanares, Jr. will represent Houston City College with distinction. Their work demonstrates that the college's VICEROY Scholars Program is not just preparing students to participate in the future national security workforce - it is preparing them to help shape it.

This selection is more than a conference milestone. It is proof that Houston City College is producing scholars capable of entering serious national security conversations now—with relevance, credibility, and purpose.